

QualiPharm Inc. — Site A (US Operations)

STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURE

Customer Complaint Handling — Finished Pharmaceutical Products

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Jurisdiction	US — Site A (FDA 21 CFR Part 211)
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1. Purpose

This Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) defines the systematic process for receiving, documenting, classifying, investigating, and resolving customer complaints related to finished pharmaceutical products manufactured or distributed by QualiPharm Inc. at Site A. This procedure ensures compliance with FDA 21 CFR Part 211.198 — Complaint Files and 21 CFR Part 211.192 — Production Record Review.

2. Scope

This SOP applies to:

- All finished pharmaceutical products manufactured at Site A, United States
- Complaints received from patients, caregivers, healthcare professionals, pharmacies, distributors, and regulatory authorities
- All personnel in Quality Assurance, Manufacturing, Customer Service, and Regulatory Affairs at Site A
- Contract testing laboratories acting on behalf of Site A

3. Regulatory References

Regulation / Guideline	Applicable Section
FDA 21 CFR Part 211.198	Complaint files — requirements for written procedures, investigation, and record retention
FDA 21 CFR Part 211.192	Production record review — batch record investigation requirements
ICH Q10	Pharmaceutical Quality System — CAPA and complaint management principles
ICH Q9	Quality Risk Management — risk-based complaint classification

FDA Guidance 2012	Investigating Out-of-Specification (OOS) Test Results
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4. Definitions

Term	Definition
Complaint	Any written, electronic, or oral communication alleging deficiencies related to the identity, quality, durability, reliability, safety, effectiveness, or performance of a drug product after it has been released for distribution.
Critical Complaint	A complaint involving confirmed or suspected patient harm, contamination, wrong product/strength, or any issue requiring immediate regulatory reporting within 3 days.
High Risk Complaint	A complaint involving contamination without confirmed patient harm, recurrent defects in the same batch or product, or sterility failures.
Medium Risk Complaint	A quality or labeling defect without patient impact or confirmed pattern. Standard investigation required within 30 days.
Low Risk Complaint	A minor cosmetic or subjective complaint with no safety implication. Investigation within 60 days.
CAPA	Corrective Action and Preventive Action — documented actions taken to eliminate the root cause of a detected non-conformity and prevent recurrence.
batch_number	The unique alphanumeric identifier assigned to a specific batch of product. Required field for complaint investigation. If unknown, complaint is placed on pending status.
Field Alert Report (FAR)	FDA report required within 3 working days for distributed products with critical safety issues per 21 CFR 314.81(b)(1).

4.1 Intake (Complaint Receipt)

All complaints must be documented within 24 hours of receipt regardless of communication channel.

- Record the complaint in the QualiTrace complaint management system with the following mandatory fields:
 - product_name — full product name including strength and dosage form
 - batch_number — from product label or carton. If unavailable, record as UNKNOWN and set case to pending_review status
 - market_code — US for all Site A products
 - complaint_type — classify as: contamination, quality, or labeling
 - patient_impact — boolean: true if patient harm reported or suspected
 - description — verbatim complaint text as reported
- If batch_number is not provided by the complainant:
 - Do NOT reject the complaint — set status to pending_review
 - Contact complainant within 48 hours to request batch number from product label

- Document follow-up attempt in complaint record
 - If batch_number cannot be obtained within 5 business days, proceed with investigation using available information
3. Assign case priority based on complaint_type and patient_impact:
- contamination + patient_impact: true → risk_level = critical → escalate to QA Director within 1 hour
 - contamination + patient_impact: false → risk_level = high → investigation within 24 hours
 - quality or labeling + patient_impact: true → risk_level = critical → escalate immediately
 - quality + patient_impact: false → risk_level = medium or low → standard investigation

4.2 Classification

The QA Reviewer classifies each complaint within 4 hours of receipt based on:

- Type of defect (contamination / quality / labeling)
- Confirmed or potential patient impact
- Recurrence — check QualiTrace for prior complaints on same product/batch
- Regulatory reporting obligation (Field Alert Report threshold)

Complaint type definitions for classification:

- contamination: Any foreign material, microbial contamination, cross-contamination, or particulate matter
- quality: Physical, chemical, or microbiological defect not involving foreign matter (e.g. appearance, potency, dissolution, stability)
- labeling: Errors in label text, missing information, wrong language, incorrect dosage instructions

4.3 Investigation

Investigation scope is determined by risk_level:

Critical and High risk investigations must include:

4. Batch record review — manufacturing, packaging, and QC release records
5. Retained sample testing — test retained samples from same batch against full specification
6. Environmental monitoring data review — for contamination complaints
7. Distribution record review — identify all affected lots in commerce
8. Root cause analysis — using fishbone diagram or 5-Why methodology
9. Regulatory assessment — determine if Field Alert Report required

Medium and Low risk investigations must include:

10. Batch record review for identified batch
11. Retained sample visual examination
12. Root cause assessment

All investigations must document: evidence_summary, root_cause_hypotheses (minimum 3 ranked by likelihood), overall_confidence score (0.0 to 1.0), and source_list (documents consulted).

4.4 CAPA

A CAPA plan must be generated for all medium, high, and critical complaints. Low risk complaints require CAPA only if root cause is identified.

Each CAPA action must specify:

- Action type: corrective (addresses current defect) or preventive (prevents recurrence)
- Description of the action
- Responsible role (e.g. QA Manager, Manufacturing Supervisor)
- Due date based on risk_level: critical = 15 days, high = 30 days, medium = 60 days, low = 90 days
- Evidence required for closure (e.g. updated SOP, training records, test data)
- Effectiveness metric — how will effectiveness be measured
- source_citations — reference to the regulatory requirement driving this CAPA

5. SLA Requirements

Risk Level	Initial Review	Investigation Complete	Case Closure
Critical	1 hour	5 business days	15 calendar days
High	4 hours	15 business days	30 calendar days
Medium	24 hours	20 business days	60 calendar days
Low	72 hours	30 business days	90 calendar days

6. Record Retention

All complaint records must be retained for a minimum of 1 year after the expiry date of the batch, or a minimum of 3 years after distribution of the batch — whichever is longer. This requirement is per FDA 21 CFR Part 211.198(a).

Retained records include: original complaint, investigation report, laboratory test results, CAPA documentation, effectiveness review, and case closure report.

7. Revision History

Version	Date	Author	Summary of Changes
3.2	Jan 2024	QA Dept	Added digital complaint system fields. Updated SLA table for critical cases.
3.1	Oct 2022	QA Dept	Updated CAPA due date requirements. Added batch_number pending procedure.

3.0	Mar 2021	QA Dept	Full revision to align with ICH Q10 principles.
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